

A NEW DAY CM Bhagwant Mann at his swearing-in, March 16

Mann's worries, from June onwards, the Centre is not obliged to provide GST compensation (roughly Rs 15,000 crore a year). That said, at Rs 15,109 crore, Punjab's GST collection for 2021-22 was the highest in five years.

Next in line is implementing the freebies and guarantees committed by his party in its poll campaign. The laundry list includes, among other things, 300 units of free electricity to every household, Rs 1,000 to every woman above 18 in the state, and a hike in old-age pension to Rs 2,500 per month. In addition to this, AAP has promised to set up 6,000 mohalla clinics and abolish property taxes. Punjab already provides free electricity to irrigate farms, free bus trips for women and a myriad other freebies. Unlike the AAP chief and Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, Mann does not have the luxury of a surplus budget (revenue surplus was Rs 1,271 crore for 2021-22 in the capital). A top official in the Punjab government told INDIA TODAY that there are avenues to augment the revenues of the state, "but for this, there is need to improve governance, compliances... and we need tough measures to plug pilferages".

Will Mann's lack of administrative experience be a liability, as many critics fear? "Experience is not a prerequisite," says Ranjit Singh Ghuman, professor of eminence at the Guru Nanak Dev University (GNDU) in Amritsar. "One requires political will and transparency in governance. The political leadership has to ensure that the message going down is very clear to the bureaucracy," he says. The immediate challenge for Mann, he says, is to restore the credibility of the government and bridge the trust deficit with the people. Along with this, Ghuman says, he needs to send a signal that the government means business and restore trust in the institutional frameworks that set the rules of the game. Following such cues, in his first verbal orders, Mann pulled the security cover of 122 former legislators and ministers.

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TASKS AT HAND

The first challenge for Mann is ensuring the smooth procurement of wheat starting next month. The Piyush Goyal-led Union ministry of consumer affairs, food and public distribution has asked Punjab to restrict wheat procurement to 13.1 million tonnes, whereas state agencies have chalked out plans to buy 13.5 MT. State officials are lobbying hard to get the Rs 29,500 crore cash credit limit (CCL) released for this.

Mann will have to work it out with Goyal to ensure maximum procurement. The state's inefficient procurement system is also a concern—it was the last in the country to make the direct payments to farmer accounts for grains procured after the last kharif season. In fact, after the curbs imposed by Goyal's ministry, state agencies are now busy linking bank accounts with digital land records to cut down inefficiencies. The Centre procures grains worth Rs 60,000 crore in the rabi (wheat) and kharif (paddy) sea-